

Diploma in Leadership & Management

Strategic awareness



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Lesson outcomes

The student will be able to understand the fundamentals of both strategic awareness and how to effectively make use of strengths-based leadership. Students will understand the impact of both and how to use both in the workplace.

Introduction

As stated by the (What is Strategic Awareness? , n.d.) “strategic awareness is a space where new ideas and innovation are constantly generated from a heightened non-contextual awareness. With this strategic awareness, leaders operate beyond the goal of competing to actively seize new and different possibilities. They live in the question and act on the possibility of things. They make the improbable or the seemingly impossible come about by bringing awareness and resources to things that lie beyond contextual reality and business-as-usual. This enhances the potentiality and probability of success enormously, ensuring that prospects and possibilities get generated into reality. Strategically aware leaders have the point of view that there is no short supply of clients and funding, and there is no limit to possibility. They are aware that an industry’s structural conditions are neither inevitable nor finite. They are able to perceive and find distinctive market positions and sustainable advantages in a multitude of ways. They recognize opportunities and seize them.”

Key reading materials:

- <https://www.weber.edu/WSUImages/leadership/docs/sq/azusa/leadership/building-team-strengths-based-leadership.pdf>
- <https://www.smartdraw.com/strategic-planning/three-kinds-of-business-strategy.htm>
- <https://www.cssp.com/strategic-awareness-a-critical-skill-in-strategic-thinking/>

Strategic awareness



As stated by (What is Strategic Awareness? , n.d.) strategic awareness places equal emphasis on both strategy and awareness. Strategic awareness is the process of fusing awareness to strategy and incorporating real-world knowledge of industry, global trends, and possible futures. It is the process of accessing non-analytic data and incorporating awareness or inner knowing into the strategic decision-making process.

Strategy and awareness are each essential to superior performance, which is the prime target of any enterprise. However, strategy and awareness work in very different ways. Awareness without strategy often results in leaders becoming mesmerized by the realm of potential possibility. They bounce from one idea to the next without any plan or strategy for carrying ideas through into physical reality. Awareness of the possibilities is important, but it's not enough.

You have to be able to bring the ideas into the world—and a sound strategy allows you to do this. Have you met people who talk on and on about their visions and aspirations, yet never create anything? In fact, many notorious big-business failures have stemmed from feeble or faulty strategies. In their book *Billion Dollar Lessons*, Paul Carroll and Chunka Mui point out that many big business failures could have been avoided if companies had been more strategically aware of potential pitfalls. It takes generative energy, will power, fortitude, and strategy to transform awareness into physical reality.

How Can You Become More Strategically Aware?

(Conscious Governance , n.d.) explains that the following can be used to improve your strategic awareness



1. Take notice of changing conditions around you, especially anomalies
2. Be the question: be curious about your customers, partners, stakeholders and generally what is happening in the world
3. Consider what is occurring in the national or global environment and look for implications for your sector or organization
4. Understand what is happening in related industries
5. Monitor interesting trends or reoccurring data (even in unrelated to you), and always ask "What, if anything, does this mean to us?"
6. Ask yourself: "what's not working here, and what do we need to do about it?"
7. Evaluate the intelligence you gather with an open mind and without preconceived judgments
8. Be prepared to take risks, manage these risks exceptionally well, and don't let opportunities pass you by.

The lack of strategic awareness:



It is important to understand the impact of what happens when companies and leaders lack strategic awareness. According to (Callegarin, n.d.)

Without Strategic Awareness:

CEOs spread conflicting organisational priorities or develop strategies based on their one-sided perspectives, imposing them on their entire organisation. They get upset when members of their Leadership Team ignore them or disagree, and require them to work with a coach to change their uncollaborative behaviour. They start big programs to spread behaviours they don't model themselves, in an attempt to increase employee engagement. When a year later nothing has changed, it's always somebody else's fault.

Without Strategic Awareness:

Companies that move into foreign markets destroy opportunities, instead of creating them. They focus on strategy without taking into account one of the key elements for a successful international business strategy: the people involved and their different views of the world. And then they wonder why their negotiations suddenly come to a halt in the Middle East, why managing their local employees is such a struggle in Japan, and why doing business in India is so difficult.

Without Strategic Awareness:

Middle managers rush from one meeting to the next one without questioning their real purpose. They work on too many projects that don't add real value, while complaining about their team, their boss, and how stressful their job is. Maintaining top performance becomes challenging, mistakes occur more frequently, and stress has a negative impact on the relationship with their colleagues, customers, and also with their loved ones.



Strength based leadership:

According to (Mindtools, n.d.) the following key points are outlined when it comes to strength based leadership.

What is strengths-based leadership?



Strengths-based leadership is the ability to identify and make the best use of your own and your team members' strengths.

Of course, this doesn't mean that you, or your team, should avoid learning new skills. But you should feel able to delegate tasks that you're not so good at to others who are more skilled or experienced.

In their 2009 book, "Strengths Based Leadership: Great Leaders, Teams, and Why People Follow," workplace consultants Tom Rath and Barry Conchie argue that the most successful teams possess a broad range of abilities. When you know each of your team members' key strengths, you can apply them in a way that benefits the team as a whole. According to (Mindtools, n.d.) strength based leadership is important for the following reasons.

Why is strengths-based leadership important?



According to (Mindtools, n.d.) strength based leadership is important for the following reasons.

A strengths-based approach can benefit your leadership and your team's performance in several ways.

First, admitting that you need help, and accepting it from your team members, promotes not only effective delegation , but also a consensual or "laissez-faire" leadership style . Asking for help is a sign of strength, not weakness, and it enables you to concentrate on what you do best.

Sharing responsibility can also stimulate creativity, innovation, and a sense of mastery and purpose within your team. When you recognize your team members' strengths, you show them that you trust their abilities. As a result, they'll likely feel more confident to speak up and express their own ideas. They'll build expert power , which can further enhance their motivation and self-worth.

Strengths-based leadership can increase team engagement and job satisfaction . A survey by Gallup found that only one percent of employees become disengaged if their managers actively focus on their strengths, while 40 percent become disengaged if their key skills are ignored.

What's more, a strengths-based approach encourages you to hire people based on their individual abilities and aptitudes, not just because their skills and experience are similar to yours. This can lead to greater team cohesion, as team members complement one another rather than compete for the same "territory." It can also produce a more diverse team, with a wider range of strengths, skill sets, attitudes, and cultural values .

Strength based exercises:

These are provided by (Freeburg, n.d.)

1. The Paper Tower Activity

The objective of the Paper Tower is for teams to build the tallest freestanding tower using only paper and masking tape.

We have written about this activity before as part of [something you could do with StrengthsFinder in 60 – 90 minutes](#). It is mentioned here again because it is such an easy and helpful activity to see strengths.

As the facilitator, you want to observe how participants interact during the planning, construction and debrief phases.

Materials you need to set this up

- A ream of paper or any discarded full sheets of paper from the recycling bin. A group of 20 people may easily use a couple hundred sheets.
- A roll of masking tape for each group.

Instructions

- Divide the larger group into teams of 4 – 6 people each.
- Give each group a roll of tape, and an arbitrary number of sheets of paper.
- Each group has 5 minutes to “design” their structure, but cannot touch the paper or tape during this time.
- Each team has 10 minutes for construction of their tower.
- It is helpful to use a visible timer so all groups can see the time remaining for each portion of this activity. Just Google, “countdown timer” and click on the first one that comes up. It is an excellent one to project on a screen.
- At the conclusion of the activity, allow for 10-15 minutes to debrief as a group. We have provided some general questions to use during the debriefing.

Benefits of this Activity

The paper tower activity easily scales to accommodate almost any size group. It can also be done inside or outside; is quick and provides enough opportunity to see some talent behaviours.

I also like it because there are three distinct phases: planning, executing, and discussion (after you are finished). You will see different people “shine” at different points.

Suggested Debrief Questions

- What did you notice during the planning vs. execution stages?
- Who stood out? Why?
- What obstacles did you run into? How did you deal with them?
- Could you see any strengths at work?

2. The Marshmallow Challenge

The objective of this activity is for groups to see who can build the tallest, freestanding structure out of spaghetti, string and tape. It differs from the Paper Tower because there are more supplies and one huge requirement... a large marshmallow must be placed on top!

This is perhaps one of my favourite StrengthsFinder activities for teams short on time. I first heard of it from a TedTalk I saw several years ago. Not only is it easy and inexpensive to set up (you can accommodate a group of up to 100 for less than \$15), but it is fun and produces some great content for discussion.

Materials you need to set this up

- 20 pieces of uncooked spaghetti noodles per team (not thin)
- 1 yard of kite string per team
- 1 yard of masking tape per team
- 1 paper lunch bag per team
- 1 large marshmallow

Instructions

- Put the uncooked spaghetti noodles, string and marshmallow into the brown paper bag. (It is often easier to give out the tape when they come grab their bag instead of trying to get it in the bag).
 - Give one bag to each group
 - Give instructions...
 - Teams have 18 minutes to build the tallest freestanding structure using only the items in the bag (and also the bag if they choose).
 - The marshmallow must be on top!
 - Set timer for 18 minutes.
 - Start timer – Go!
 - Measure towers at the end
 - Declare a winner!
 - Debrief
-

Benefits of this Activity

One of the reasons I like it is because it requires collaboration from participants in a short time frame. It is great because it “reveals very deep lessons about the nature of collaboration...” We believe strengths are most alive when generativity engaged on a team. Naturally collaboration is important.

Placing the marshmallow on top without proper support will topple the tower. Most teams wait until the very end to see if it will be able to support the weight. Often, it does not.

When we use this activity, we talk about how building a strengths based culture takes a bit of trial and error. You need to build a little and see how the structure will stand up to outside pressure. It's ok if it topples. That's part of the process. Don't be afraid to experiment and take a few risks.

Suggested Debrief Questions

- What did you notice?
- Who stood out? Why?
- Who seemed to be taking charge? How?
- Could you see any strengths at work? Give examples.

3. Nuclear Disposal

The objective of this StrengthsFinder activity for teams is to transport the “nuclear hot orb” from the “contamination” silo to the “safety” silo. This takes a bit more prep than the others, but is really valuable and provides several levels of behavioral observations.

The following is designed to accommodate a group 5 – 8 people. If you have much more than that, you can either create multiple sets, or just have them take turns.

Materials

Before you start, look at the above picture... that's what it will look like when you're done.

- 2 small traffic cones
- 2, 4" PVC couplers ([like this](#))
- 1 tennis ball, 1 softball, 1 small playground ball. You only need all 3 if you are going to make multiple attempts at this activity. Each ball creates a different level of challenge because they are weighted differently.
- 100 ft of 1/4", nylon rope, cut into 8, 10 – 12 foot lengths.

Setup

This activity will require a bit of “at home” prep. It's not hard, it will just take you perhaps 30 minutes (once you have all the supplies purchased).

- Drill 8, 1/4" holes around the outside of the PVC coupler.
- Thread a piece of rope through each hole, tying a knot on the inside of the coupler so it forms a 10' handle.
- Repeat for each hole.

Instructions

- Place the traffic cone at one end of a “playing field” (can be any location, indoors or out). Place the second one at the other end of the room (distance doesn't matter). The farther away, the more difficult the challenge. Feel free to place various obstacles in the way if it seems too easy.
 - Rest the coupler on top of the traffic cone, with all ropes neatly spread out (or in a tangled mess for added difficulty).
 - Rest one of the balls (starting with the lightest first tends to be easiest) on top of the coupler, balancing on the cone.
 - Each member of your team must grab one of the ropes attached to the coupler.
 - Using only the ropes (no hands allowed), pick up the nuclear hot orb and transport it to the safety silo.
 - If orb falls off – start over!
 - Participants may not touch any part of the rope except the last 6 inches. It is helpful to tie little knots as a way to indicate.
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Benefits of this Activity

This challenge is designed to observe the way team members adapt to changing circumstances. In much the same way as the real world environment can change at a moment's notice, this challenge forces participants to flex and adapt with the experience as the facilitator changes the rules/environment as they go.

You will see how people with different strengths approach the idea of flexibility and change.

Suggested Debrief Questions

- How do your strengths enable you to adapt to a change in your environment?
- How do the actions of another team member (negative or positive) affect your ability to adapt?
- How do you respond when changes in the environment are beyond your control? When they are within your control?
- What strengths could you see at work? Give examples

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